as well as mid-twentieth-century leaders like Guru Golwalkar. Yet, its construction of ‘Hindu’ and ‘Hindutva’ is predicated on the concept of defence against an ‘other’. This ‘other’ may not necessarily be Muslim or Christian. It could be rival concepts of India, rival notions of Hinduism or even the distinction that the RSS draws between Bharat (the indigenous nation) and India (the Western construct). The ‘chief theoretician of modern Hindu nationalism’, V.D. Savarkar, was never part of the RSS, but his celebration of the word ‘Hindutva’ in the celebrated 1923 pamphlet, *Hindutva: Who Is a Hindu?*, remains a critical theoretical underpinning for much of Hindutva thinking, as Swapan Dasgupta has pointed out.[44] For Savarkar, Hindutva was not a ‘word, but a history’; ‘Hinduism’ was only a ‘derivative, a fraction, a part of Hindutva’.[45]

Yet, there is a crucial difference between Savarkar’s idea of Hindutva and that of the RSS. Syama Prasad Mookerjee left the Hindu Mahasabha in 1949 because Savarkar did not give in to his insistence on membership for non-Hindus. Savarkar’s definition of being Hindu meant a person who regarded ‘the land of Bharatvarsha from the Indus to the seas as his fatherland (pitribhumi) as well as his holy land (punyabhumi), that is the cradle land of his religion’. This narrow definition, predicated on religion, automatically put Muslims and Christians (whose holy lands are outside India) outside the ambit of nationalism.[46]

The Sangh’s notion of cultural Hindu nationalism—where it accepts those from other religions and promises equality of religion, language and food habits, with the caveat that they accept the cultural primacy of Hinduness—as Indianness itself, is different from the Nehruvian idea of India, but it is also distinct from Savarkar’s conception. Mohan Bhagwat pointed out in his 2019 Vijayadashami address that, although the RSS was focused on ‘organising the Hindu society’, this did not mean that it harboured ‘hatred against those sections, especially Muslims and Christians, who do not call themselves Hindu’. He said, ‘Those who belong to Bharat, those of who are descendants of Bharatiya ancestors, those who are working for the ultimate glory of the nation and joining hands in enhancing peace by mingling with each other and accepting, respecting and welcoming all diversities; all those Bharatiyas are Hindus.’ Whether